

PORCELAIN

Craftsmen in Europe had perfected the porcelain-making process in the mid-18th century, and by the mid-19th century, bone china studios in Europe and England experienced a boom in business as they tried to keep up with demand for afternoon tea sets.



BONE CHINA

Fine bone china cups and saucers had gilded edges to catch the lamp light in the evenings.



Darjeeling tea

THE SUEZ CANAL

The Suez Canal opened in 1869, making the passage of steam ships from tea-producing countries in the East to Europe and North America economically viable where it had not been before. Passage was swift in these larger, faster steamships, so for the first time ever the Western market could drink fresh tea.

1840

First, unsuccessful, attempt by the British to grow tea in Ceylon (Sri Lanka)

1869

The Suez canal opens, and steamships are able to cut costs and time on trips to Asia. With coffee crop failure in Ceylon, tea planting begins in earnest

1840s

Clipper ships speed the delivery of tea to America

1869

The British start growing tea in Sri Lanka. The ready supply of tea leads to a dramatic fall in prices

1872

The first steam-powered rolling machines are used in Assam, reducing the time and cost of tea production

TEA AT SEA

In the first half of the century, ships had to sail around Africa's Cape of Good Hope to reach Britain and the US. The newly invented clipper ship's low, sleek design and square rigged sails helped it travel at up to 20 knots per hour, bringing cargoes of tea to port in half the time of older vessels. The Cutty Sark, one of the last merchant ships to be built, carried tea until 1877.

Clipper ship



INDIAN TEAS

In the second half of the 19th century, tea plantations prospered in India, and new land was cleared every year during Queen Victoria's reign (1837-1901). India produced excellent black teas that were in demand in Europe, Australia, and North America.